Development.

She made a mark as the country's first woman IPS officer. Bidding the police service adieu, Kiran Bedi lamented that her sisters in the force continued to be an unknown entity.

'Women are still an unknown entity in the force. They remain anonymous,' said Bedi. She was also critical of the 'negative' political interference in policing, saying it was affecting the efficiency of police in the country.

'There are no debates in the country about police and its reforms. There are no police officers who speak out and there is nobody to speak for policemen,' she said.

On criticism that she was the 'most pampered' officer, she said: 'If I was a pampered officer, I would not have spent four years in the training department. Not a single pampered officer goes to Tihar.' On receiving her relieving letter, Bedi said she went to a temple to say 'God, Thank You and now take care of me'.

(*Deccan Herald*, 28 December 2007)

I had put in 35 long years in the service, marked by constant opposition. I had dared to persistently challenge the old order against all odds, despite facing envy and sabotage at virtually every step of my career. I had had enough of repeatedly hearing, '*if you cannot be a part of the system, why don't you get out?*' It was time for me to finally reject the envious and the suffocating glass ceiling; it was not possible for me to break through, in the given set of circumstances.

Looking back, it appears that a strong feeling of exasperation had been building up within me and being overlooked for this ultimate responsibility of my career became the last straw.

Over the years, I had the opportunity to attend a few annual conferences of the directors general of police. They began with the prime minister reading out a written speech prepared by the bureaucracy. The media was duly invited, which disseminated the written speech, with familiar sound bites being provided by the electronic media. After that, I never saw the emergence of any united-vigorous-courageous chorus, particularly on long-term police reforms. Nor did I come across a serious quest for audit or accountability with regard to past decisions taken at the earlier conferences. I am personally privy to the management of pending issues shown as matters under consideration with committees (set up just before the conference).

The bureaucracy forms the core of the nation's mammoth administrative apparatus. The bureaucrats are considered the 'invisible controllers [*sic*]' of such a system. Unfortunately, over the decades, many a system under their responsibility has become virtually stagnant and regressive at times. Anyone from outside their service who dared to bring about a change was subconsciously a direct threat to them. The only way such an individual could survive in the bureaucratic 'fiefdom' was by conforming to their mindset and by becoming a pygmy.

By mid-2007, I had reached the top of the police ranks as far as my service was concerned. I was the DGP (director general of police) of a Central police organization under the aegis of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), Government of India, New Delhi. By virtue of my position, aptitude and capacity, I ought to have been optimally used. Instead, the organization where I was then positioned was substantially marginalized. My very presence became an eyesore (as I sensed) for the aforementioned 'controllers'. This was because I was now a witness to their negative machinations. I saw this top-level coterie marginalizing police leadership, much to the detriment of the nation and its people. And the consequences are there for all to see today. The Indian police has an overwhelming